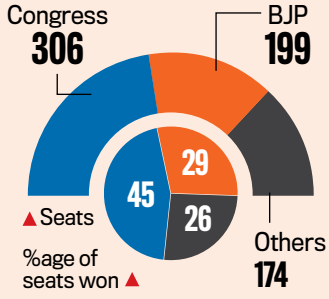
THE STAKES IN THE 5 STATES

Constituencies **679**	Total voters **161 million**
First-time voters **6.2 million**	Women voters **78 million**

PAST RESULTS

2018
Assembly polls in Rajasthan, MP, Chhattisgarh, Telangana & Mizoram



HONING THEIR STRATEGIES

CONGRESS

- Like in Karnataka, offering 'guarantees' or state-specific socio-economic doles
- Raising the volume on a national caste census to wean OBCs away from BJP
- Highlighting local issues and giving local satraps a free hand to design campaigns

THE BJP

- Channelling PM Narendra Modi's popularity
- Fielding parliamentarians, including Union ministers, in pursuit of winnability
- Playing up the G20 success, women's reservation bill and reduced LPG cylinder prices

a nationwide caste census. On October 2, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar published the results of a caste survey in which OBCs (Other Backward Classes) were found to be 63 per cent of the state's population, far higher than the 52 per cent in the 1931 Census that formed the basis of the Mandal Commission's calculations. Since then, the clamour for a caste census has only grown, with most political parties saying that the Supreme Court-mandated 50 per cent cap on reservations in government jobs and educational institutes must go for OBCs to get more than the current 27 per cent quota after Scheduled Castes and Tribes exhaust the remaining 22.5 per cent.

On October 9, the day the Election Commission announced the poll schedule for the five states, the Congress Working Committee passed a resolution promising that it will conduct a national caste census if voted to power at the Centre. The clear intent is to woo the OBC vote that has been a key factor in the BJP's electoral wins in the past decade. Not only has the BJP succeeded in promoting OBC icons, history and culture and increased their representation within the party and government, it has also managed to subsume caste identities under a broader Hindutva umbrella and cultivated a larger *labharthi* (beneficiary) vote bank, where the economic rationale overrides caste or religion.

Hence the BJP rivals are upping the ante on a caste census, even as the saffron side has remained non-committal on the issue, fearing a backlash from its old savarna voters. Other than Mizoram, the poll-bound states have an OBC population of more than 40 per cent, which makes them a perfect laboratory to test the caste census plank. The key to its success or failure will also lie in how the 6.2 million first-time voters in these states respond to the campaign.

The caste census is but one googly, there are other challenges for the BJP in this round of assembly polls. The party, which makes a virtue out of projecting a strong leadership, has avoided naming a chief ministerial candidate in any of the five states. Instead, it will be channelling Prime Minister Narendra Modi's popularity, even though the strategy backfired in the Himachal Pradesh election last year and in Karnataka this year.

What remains unchanged is the central leadership's tight control over all aspects of the elections. More than a dozen parliamentarians have been fielded in Rajasthan, MP and Chhattisgarh. The party is also hoping to capitalise on the success of the G20, the launch of Chandrayaan-3, the women's reservation bill and the reduction in LPG cylinder prices. Women voters have been a mainstay of the BJP's electoral success and the party has begun a concerted campaign to reach out to the female electorate. There are 78 million women voters in the five states, nearly half the total electorate.

The Congress, on the other hand, buoyed by its successes in Himachal and Karnataka, hopes to extend its winning streak and even break new ground in Telangana. Despite the inner squabbling, the Grand Old Party has been able to settle the leadership issue in all states, particularly in the two states where it's in power. With its CM faces in place, the Congress is building its campaign mostly around local issues and "guarantees" (read freebies) to different groups.

That said, anti-incumbency will be a stumbling block for the Congress in Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh. The outcome of these polls will also determine the stature and bargaining power of the Congress in INDIA in terms of seat-sharing arrangements for the Lok Sabha polls. The November elections may or may not have a direct bearing on the 2024 general election, but they will certainly help test the political waters. ■

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY